through this system upwards to the headquarters. RMA is going to be manifest in a very effective manner at the cutting edge, that is, the infantryman.'[1]

The infantry urgently requires a state-of-the-art close-quarter-battle (CQB) carbine to replace the existing obsolete weapon. As the Defence Research and Development Organization (DRDO) made a bid to make an indigenous carbine, we had to give them a chance. Finally, their product failed to meet our requirements and we had to carry out trials of imported models. To keep the costs low and to give our ordnance factory an opportunity, I proposed that we should have two types of carbines in our army, one for the infantry for a specialized CQB role, which must match the best in the world, and the second for the rest of the army, which should be the best indigenous product. I am happy this proposal stands accepted by the government and the acquisition process is on. When I visited Oman as the chief in 2005, they scheduled a visit to the army's museum. I was shocked to see a 9-mm carbine of the type we are currently using, and which we had also supplied to the Omanese army in the 1960s, displayed as a museum piece!

The ageing fleet of army aviation helicopters is being upgraded. Since 2004, modern helicopters are being tried out so that we could replace the Cheetahs and Chetaks of 1960s vintage. In addition, our indigenous 'Dhruv' advanced light helicopters (ALH) are also being inducted. I distinctly remember that during the ALH desert trials, the prototype came to Rajasthan during Operation Parakaram (2002) and we had flown in it. I found it to be a very powerful and robust machine, though at that time there were some glitches noticed too. The biggest advantage that accrues with this aircraft is the carrying capacity. The entire 'R' (recce) group of the Corps HQ could move in one helicopter. As far as the engineers are concerned, modern equipment for mine laying and breaching is in the pipeline, as are bridges.

We are now ushering in the era of the digitized battle field. Commanders, their staff, the fighting units, weapon systems, battlefield sensors and other entities will be interconnected by robust and fully secure digital information and communication